ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Are We Ruled by the Stars? Demons, Angels and Astrology

Derech Hashem, Maamar Halkarim

Sefer: Maamar Halkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar Halkarim, essay 2: the spiritual realm (second part)
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These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

On Monday the Ramhal taught that the spiritual world, like the physical one, has laws and boundaries. It has three main categories: the kohot, the forces behind everything that exists; the malakhim, the messengers who bring things down to fruition; and the neshamot, the souls, with different laws before, during and after their time in the body.

Shedim: a hybrid creature

The Ramhal now describes another kind of creature, a hybrid between the physical and spiritual worlds. It is partly bound by physical laws but not entirely. These are the shedim, demons. They have some physicality, though not flesh and blood like ours, and some spiritual properties, though not fully spiritual. As always, a general category contains many levels, each with its own laws.

The Rabbi noted that the Ramhal clearly affirms the existence of demons, based on many passages in the Gemara. One example is the statement that the Rabbis' clothes wore out because demons rubbed against them in the beit midrash. The Rambam rejected all of this and held there are no demons; such passages are not literal. "Depends how you define it," the Rabbi added.

A participant asked whether demons enter people. The Rabbi answered that the idea of possession is not written anywhere until about 500 years ago, and should not be mixed up with what the Gemara says. Demons are external. Exactly what they are is unclear, but their role seems to be to cause trouble. He distinguished them from the malakhei habalah, the destructive messengers, which carry out God's word to bring harm. Demons seem to be given some room for chaos within the system, which God can always stop.

Everything below has a root above

Next comes a principle repeated throughout the past two years: nothing in this world, neither a thing nor a circumstance, lacks a parallel in the upper world. Everything has its koah above it.

What then happens to that thing, whether it exists, is damaged or destroyed, comes down through a malakh. That flow of spiritual energy is called hashpaah.

A participant asked whether every atom and every bacterium has its own angel. The Rabbi cited the Midrash that there is no blade of grass below without its counterpart above. Perhaps the blade of grass was simply the smallest thing they knew. "If you can do every blade of grass, you can do every atom as well."

Through the stars

All this energy, from the koah through the malakh, passes through the stars and constellations on its way down, which is why astrology has a great effect on this world. The Rabbi reminded the group that in Part 2 they had a whole chapter on astrology. The Rambam rejected it entirely, while the Ramhal believes in it, as does the Gemara.

His analogy: water poured through jugs of different colours. The water is the same, but it comes out looking red, orange, blue or yellow. The stars are like those jugs. The Gemara in Shabbat says a person born under Mars will be drawn to shedding blood, as a murderer, a shohet or a mohel. The same nature can be channelled in very different ways.

Ein mazal leYisrael

The Gemara also says that Israel is not subject to mazal. The Rabbi explained: if you abandon yourself to the forces of nature, you go through the stars. But if you connect directly to God, the koah and malakh are only an extension of Him, and you are above the constellations.

This, he said, is why charms can be harmful. "People say, what's wrong with something red on my hand? You've got plenty to lose from it." You are putting yourself under the influence of nature and appealing to the servant instead of the source. "This is why these things are dangerous, in my opinion." He added that a non-Jew too can place himself directly under God. It all depends on how a person relates to Him.

Changing nature, within limits

In the final paragraph the Ramhal says God placed in the forces, the messengers and the stars the ability to be stirred by human beings to act beyond nature. A table is subject to gravity because its koah says so. If someone could tap into the koah, or more easily the star above it, with some kind of incantation, it could be made to act differently. "That's how practical Kabbalah works."

But even this is not a free-for-all. No force or messenger can do whatever it wants. Each has a maximum boundary. Some ways of doing this are permitted, such as the methods of Sefer Yesirah, and some are forbidden, such as witchcraft. People who think that being in touch with the spiritual lets them do whatever they want are mistaken. "It doesn't work like that."

The next class, the week before Shavuot, would begin the third essay.

Summary

- Shedim are a hybrid of physical and spiritual; the Ramhal accepts them from the Gemara, the Rambam does not.
- Everything physical has a koah above it, and what happens to it comes down through a malakh.
- That flow passes through the stars, but a person who connects directly to God rises above mazal.
- Charms and segulot place a person under nature instead of under God.
- Spiritual forces can be stirred to change nature, but only within set limits and by permitted means.

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